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Laptops

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It was only a matter of time. Less than a decade ago they started to miniaturize laptops to a whole new level. Then in the face of insurmountable smartphone and tablet demand, the mission was interrupted. But like a phoenix rising from its ashes, the second coming of netbooks was inevitable, and they've definitely come a long way.

To begin with, they're no longer referred to as netbooks anymore, just thin and light laptops. They're no longer restricted to a 10-inch form factor, with almost all thin notebooks now gravitating to a 11-inch form factor. Their specifications, features and designs have also evolved with changing times – depending on your price budget, you can buy a 11-inch ultraportable for as little as 15k, for a touchscreen device you can spend anywhere between 20k to 30k, and for a 2-in-1 tablet-note-

book hybrid the asking price is as low as 25k.

The trend of shrinking laptop form factors finally being available at an affordable cost is a breath of fresh air, especially in the ultraportable laptop category – where traditionally OEMs tried to focus their efforts in the premium segment. That's no longer the case. Another market reality adding to the growth of 11-inch laptops or 2-in-1s is the shrinking tablet space – tablet sales have seriously nose-dived over the past

18 months, and this has given manufacturers added impetus to refocus their energies on perfecting tiny laptops once again.

If there's one thing we realized from this comparison test, by looking at candidates from Acer, ASUS, Dell, HP and Lenovo, is that despite shrinking laptop dimensions, their hardware performance has marginally increased (as compared to the netbooks of old) but battery life has shrunk a bit – make no mistakes, this is still a lot better than main-

HOW WE TESTED

Initial setup: We tested these 11 inch thin and light laptops much like any other laptop we benchmark. All laptops to be tested were first examined and everything about them is catalogued, including bundled software, accessories, etc. We then delete the antivirus and other 'bloatware' from the system to ensure minimal performance impact on the devices. Drivers and essential software are updated. Finally, the devices are set to run in performance mode in the BIOS as well as in the power options. All performance inhibitors are turned off, as much as possible – stuff like hard drive idling to sleep, screen switching off, screen dimming on battery mode, etc. After this, the laptops are ready to go into the grinder of our performance benchmarks.

Performance tests: We conduct a whole series of tests on the devices to measure the impact of every aspect of the system on overall performance – tests that stress the laptop's CPU, RAM, GPU, hard drive, screen, thermals, battery, and more. These tests include industry standard benchmarks including (and not limited to) Futuremark's PCMark 8 and 3D Mark, MAXON Cinebench, and others. We use PCMark 8's Creative test suite to evaluate battery life of each laptop, as well. Results are carefully catalogued.

Screen brightness and contrast ratio is measured using the DataColor Spyder 4 Elite test unit – a color calibrator. It's essential to calibrate all laptop displays before objectively testing them, and we do just that. In dark rooms with little or no ambient light, the laptops are tested with Datacolor Spyder Studio.

Brightness and contrast is tested at different luminance level, and an average of multiple readings is taken as the final score. We also test the screen's gradient through DisplayMate and Lagom.nl.

A series of subjective testing is also conducted that scores aspects such as a laptop's keyboard, touchpad, palmrest, screen readability, onboard speakers, look and feel, watching movies, playing games (if the laptop is meant for gaming), among others. These tests help complete the gamut of objective benchmarks with real-world test scenarios, allowing us to take a fairly homogeneous look at the laptop's overall pros and cons.

The final performance score is arrived at which includes the weighted sum of all the scores catalogued. Weights are assigned based on the perceived importance of the components. For example, since gaming doesn't really matter or all that important on a business laptop, gaming benchmarks and scores from them are of lesser importance here than they would be on a home entertainment or gaming laptop. Stuff like battery life, screen brightness, CPU performance will be of significantly greater importance in a business setup.

Features score: The features present in each laptop are tabulated and given weighted scores depending on perceived importance. For example, dedicated multimedia keys and volume keys are given more weightage than those that are shared with Fn keys. An important note on features, we don't rate CPU, GPU, RAM characteristics any weight here, because

we feel those characteristics already surface in the performance part of our testing. Example - Whether a laptop has a dual-core or quad-core laptop doesn't get lesser or higher points because both of these laptop's performances take those aspect into account. Features that directly impact performance are not counted or scored here.

Design and Usability: The scores for this parameter are largely subjective as they indicate our experience with the device. Items such as quality of the keyboard, responsiveness of the touch-screen, etc. are weighted and scored.

Final score: The final score that we arrive at is the sum of the performance, features and design scores with a variable individual weightage. This is not a fixed weightage, and depending on the category of laptops we're testing, these weightages can be different. For this particular comparison, we gave performance, features, design and price 40%, 20%, 30% and 30%, respectively.

A note on winners: The Best Buy laptop is awarded to the device with the best price to performance ratio based on a predetermined formula. This is the ideal, value for money product in the test. The Best Performer award is awarded to the device with the highest overall performance score. The Editor's Pick award is awarded to the device that the reviewer feels is the best product that offers something extra or unique that none of the other laptops have. The Editor's Pick is an entirely subjective award, the decision for which is based on the reviewer's experience while testing the products.